

CHAPTER 19

ANTONY WILL KILL AGAIN

'I have been praying to God to keep him alive till I get out.'

I was slowly getting used to the routine at Viyyur jail, though sleep continued to elude me. Around 6 am, we—Sasi, Chandra, Sharma and I—were let out of our cells for our bath. We were not allowed to mingle with the other prisoners, so we had to get back our cells by 6.15 am, before the others can be let out.

At 8 am, breakfast was served on the verandah—again, before or after the others had it. The food was not bad—idli, dosa or wheat balls for breakfast. Almost every day there came a banana with the breakfast. Lunch, served between 12 pm and 1 pm was mostly rice and a curry. The menu had non-vegetarian food four days a week: one day chicken, two days of fish and one day of mutton or beef.

One of the first things Sasi asked me after coming to prison was whether I was a vegetarian. I was not, but knowing that he was eyeing my share of non-vegetarian prison food, I happily offered him. After twenty-seven days in the prison, when Sasi was out on bail, many told him that he had put on weight. He promptly thanked me for all that chicken and mutton I sacrificed for him.

A few convicts were given the job to cook rice, which they did in a cauldron in the open. Some others would serve food, each one had to wash his steel plate and cup. One of the inmates who served rice was a young man, probably in his early twenties. He had no expression on his face, but